It is not for this fortuitous mixing of royal blood, however, that Abul Fazl tells the story; he has far grander claims to make. Learned astrologers may have seen Timur's bright fortune in Qachulay's eighth star, but Abul Fazl's own interpretation of the facts indicates that its 'resplendent light' could only mean the 'holy personality of . . . [Akbar] the King of Kings who hath by the light of his Being illumined the terrene and terrestrials'. Thus, as Corinne Lefèvre argues in an enlightening essay on the link between Qachulay's dreams and Akbar's reality, Abul Fazl uses 'genealogy . . . in support of the exceptional status now claimed by the emperor and, consequently, of his divine right to rule'.[28]

It would be a while before either Akbar or his historian made their claims explicit. However, it may be no coincidence that now, at about the same time that Abul Fazl's father, Shaikh Mubarak, drafted his mahzar, he 'also suggested . . . that Akbar embodied *farr*, the pre-Islamic Iranian concept of a divinely bestowed charismatic essence'.[29] Or, as Abul Fazl would write one day, summoning all the rhetorical force of a clear truth told in simple terms: Akbar was 'a lamp for the dark world'.[30]

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On 7 September 1579, a week after the Infallibility Decree had been signed and proclaimed, and possibly as a result of the furore it created, Akbar left Fatehpur for Ajmer, once again. It had long been his habit to visit Shaikh Moinuddin Chishti's dargah before and after any great enterprise and yet, though Akbar had won as great a victory against his jurists as against any Uzbek or Mirza, Abul Fazl insists that this time the emperor travelled reluctantly. The blessings of Ajmer's Chishti saint had been integral to Akbar's rule these past decades, but now he only went as a way of 'calming the public' – all those 'ignobles' stomping in protest, no doubt.[31]

En route, the emperor was met by a far more agreeable gathering of his subjects. They wanted to tell Akbar the story of a traveller who was going past 'a dreadful forest' nearby when he ran into a hungry lion that 'rose up to destroy his life'. Terrified, the man drew a circle around himself and 'called upon the name of the world's lord'. At Akbar's name, the lion stopped in its tracks. The traveller lived to tell his tale.[32]

Did Akbar wonder, as he heard the story and promised never to hunt a lion